# Washington’s Farewell Address

*President George Washington · September 19, 1796 · excerpts*

*Source: George Washington, Farewell Address (1796), text via the Avalon Project, Yale Law School. Public domain.*

As Washington prepared to leave office after two terms, he published a long letter — co-drafted with Hamilton and Madison — to ‘Friends and Fellow Citizens.’ He warned against three dangers he saw threatening the young republic: partisan faction, sectionalism between the regions, and entangling alliances with European powers. The address shaped American political culture for over a century.

*Connect: The Articles of Confederation failed partly because Congress couldn’t tax. How does Hamilton’s plan directly address that weakness?*

## Key Passages

### On sectionalism

> The name of American, which belongs to you in your national capacity, must always exalt the just pride of patriotism more than any appellation derived from local discriminations. … You have in a common cause fought and triumphed together; the independence and liberty you possess are the work of joint counsels, and joint efforts of common dangers, sufferings, and successes.

### On political parties

> warn you in the most solemn manner against the baneful effects of the spirit of party generally. … It serves always to distract the public councils and enfeeble the public administration. It agitates the community with ill-founded jealousies and false alarms, kindles the animosity of one part against another, foments occasionally riot and insurrection. … It opens the door to foreign influence and corruption, which finds a facilitated access to the government itself through the channels of party passions.

### On foreign alliances

> The great rule of conduct for us in regard to foreign nations is in extending our commercial relations, to have with them as little political connection as possible. … Europe has a set of primary interests which to us have none; or a very remote relation. … It is our true policy to steer clear of permanent alliances with any portion of the foreign world; so far, I mean, as we are now at liberty to do it;

## HIPP Analysis

*Model answers fill the first three rows. Use them to explain the author's Purpose in the last row.*

| HIPP Element | Your Analysis |
|---|---|
| ***Historical Situation***<br>*What was happening when this was written?* | The end of Washington's second term (1796): fights between Federalists and Democratic-Republicans, the Jay Treaty controversy, and the war between Britain and France. |
| ***Intended Audience***<br>*Who was the source written for?* | The American people ('Friends and Fellow Citizens'); it was printed in newspapers as an open letter, not delivered as a speech. |

| HIPP Element | Your Analysis |
| --- | --- |
| ***Point of View***<br>*Whose perspective? Whose is missing?* | Washington, the retiring first president and former general, who stood above party and worried that the young republic was fragile. |
| ***Purpose***<br>*What did the author want to accomplish?* | |

## Analysis Prompts

1. HIPP analysis — Point of View: How does Washington's position as outgoing president shape what he chooses to warn about?
2. Identify TWO specific events of the 1790s that prompted these warnings.
3. Compare Washington's foreign-policy advice with U.S. behavior in any later period of your choice.